show any signs of melancholy,' Bukh wrote later. 'I went to see him on the eve of his tragic death; he was excited about some article in a German newspaper referring to him. He showed me the rifles and pistols, his life-long passion, he had bought in the East. On his return to the hotel he was in good spirits, and had asked to be woken at nine.'

The oddly terse tone of the suicide note also fuelled speculation: why was there no mention of his mother, his brother or any of his colleagues and friends? The first to express his suspicions in print was the Tsarist military historian M. A. Terntyev. 'The investigation did not lead to anything,' he wrote, 'but it is difficult to believe that someone who had worked hard for so many years to further his career would give it up the night before his most ardent dreams were to come true . . . Many suspected the British to be involved in this mysterious incident . . . Who but the British were interested in Vitkevich's papers? Who but the British were exasperated by Burnes's failure and angry with Vitkevich? . . .Vitkevich's death deprived us of important intelligence on Afghanistan; the treaty he had signed with Amir Dost Mohammad also vanished.' This was certainly a version of events that appealed to N. A. Khalfin, the Cold War-era Soviet historian of the Great Game: 'What was it then?' he asked. 'Murder, committed in the centre of St Petersburg, upon the order of a certain foreign power?'[7]

But there is a third version of the events in the Paris Boarding House, which is the one that is generally believed in Vitkevitch's native Poland, and which perhaps rings most true. For, according to one of his Orenburg colleagues, at the theatre the night before he died Vitkevitch – or rather Jan Prosper Witkiewicz as he was still known to his fellow Poles – ran into an old friend from Vilnius. This friend, Tyshkevitch, berated him, angrily asserting that he had at one time been willing to sacrifice himself in the name of his motherland but had now lost all his ideals, abandoning his dearest principles for the sake of naked ambition.

The earliest source for this are some notes of Colonel P. I. Sungurov, who served in Orenburg for thirty years and knew Vitkevitch well. According to Sungurov, after the play Vitkevitch had returned to his hotel to pull together his plans and notes in preparation for the audience with the Tsar the following morning. Late that night, Tyshkevitch came to see Vitkevitch in his rooms, knocking on his door as the traveller sat surrounded by his papers and journals. Vitkevitch's tale of his travels, of the 'great service' he had done to Russia and of his exciting future career provoked Tyshkevitch's